Scott Tischler

FOUNDER & CHAIRMAN · AIRECOMMEND.AI

HOW AI WORKS

The Attribution Problem: When AI Credits Your Work to Someone More Famous

By Scott Tischler · October 21, 2026 · 8 min read

You can do the original thinking, coin the term, build the framework, publish it first — and still watch an AI credit it to someone more famous who wrote about it after you. This is the attribution problem, and it's one of the most frustrating ways AI visibility goes sideways for people who actually have the ideas. Understanding why models collapse credit toward prominent names is the first step to keeping your name attached to your own work.

I see this most with founders, specialists, and independent thinkers — the people whose entire asset is being known for an idea. They notice that when they ask an AI who originated a concept they clearly originated, the answer names a bigger publication, a well-known author, or simply "experts" in general. The credit flowed uphill to prominence, past the person who did the work. It stings, and it's not paranoia. It's a predictable consequence of how these systems resolve who gets credit.

Why AI collapses credit toward the famous

Start with what a model is actually doing when it attributes an idea. It isn't consulting a ledger of who published what first. It's pattern-matching over everything it has absorbed, and asking, in effect, "whose name shows up most often and most confidently near this concept?" That's a popularity-and-corroboration question, not an origination question. And popularity and origination are very different things.

The person who originated an idea often published it once, quietly, on a small platform. The famous person who later wrote about it published it loudly, got amplified, got quoted, got linked, got discussed. By the time the model absorbs the web, the concept is densely associated with the prominent name and thinly associated with the originator. The model isn't lying — it's faithfully reporting the association it found. The association is just wrong about who came first, because the web itself recorded the loud version more thoroughly than the original one.

There's a second mechanism underneath this. When a model is uncertain, it defaults to the safe, prominent answer — the same way it defaults to national brands for generic queries. Crediting a famous name for an idea is low-risk for the model: it's probably what the user expects, and it's defensible. Crediting an obscure name is high-risk — if the model is wrong, it looks foolish attributing a known concept to a stranger. So uncertainty itself biases the answer toward prominence. My read is that these two forces — denser association and risk-aversion under uncertainty — compound, and the originator gets squeezed out of the credit.

What this looks like in practice

Picture the realistic sequence, because the mechanism is clearer as a story than as a principle. You publish a framework on your own blog. It's genuinely yours and it's first. A handful of people read it. Months later, a well-known writer with a large audience publishes their own take on the same idea — maybe they encountered yours, maybe they arrived at it independently, it doesn't matter for what happens next. Their version gets shared widely, quoted, linked from other prominent sites, discussed in comment threads and newsletters and podcasts. Each of those secondary mentions ties the concept a little more tightly to their name.

Now a model absorbs all of it. It sees the idea once, faintly, near your name, and dozens of times, loudly, near theirs. When someone later asks who's behind the concept, the model returns the dense association — the famous name — because that's what the web, as recorded, overwhelmingly says. Nothing malicious happened. No single actor decided to steal your credit. The internet simply documented the loud version more thoroughly than the original, and the model inherited that imbalance. That's the uncomfortable part: the attribution problem usually isn't theft, it's math, and it runs on exactly the signals you'd have to build on your side to counter it.

Why this is worse than it sounds

For a business, being miscategorized is bad. For a thought leader, being mis-attributed is existential, because the work *is* the asset. If AI systems become the default way people learn who thinks about what, and they consistently route credit for your ideas to someone else, you don't just lose a citation — you lose the compounding. Every time the idea gets discussed, the association with the wrong name strengthens, which makes the model more confident in the wrong attribution, which makes it more likely to repeat it. It's a flywheel spinning in the wrong direction.

And it's quiet. Nobody tells you your idea has been reassigned. You find out by accident, usually when you ask the question yourself and brace for an answer that names you and instead hears a stranger's work described in your own words under someone else's name.

The deeper cost is strategic. If you're building a personal brand or a business on the premise that you're the one who understands a particular thing, attribution *is* your positioning. Lose it quietly inside AI answers and you don't just miss a credit — you let the market's mental model of your category form around someone else, which is far harder to undo than it would have been to defend in the first place. That's why I treat this as urgent rather than annoying. The window to establish a dense association with your own idea is widest right after you publish it, and it narrows as the louder version accumulates.

How to keep credit attached to your work

- **Attach your name to the idea every single time.** The originator's mistake is usually publishing the idea once and moving on. Prominent people win attribution partly by repetition — they keep saying the thing, in public, under their name. If you coined it, don't say it once. Build a consistent body of work where your name and the concept appear together so often that the association becomes dense on your side too.
- **Own the definition, not just the mention.** Be the source that explains the idea most clearly and completely. Models gravitate to the cleanest, most authoritative articulation of a concept when they explain it. If your version is the most quotable and extractable explanation, you become the natural thing to cite for it — which is a route back to attribution even when you're not the most famous name in the room.
- **Get corroboration from others, not just yourself.** You claiming you originated something is self-interested; the model knows that. What moves attribution is other credible sources crediting *you* — a mention in someone else's piece, a reference in an interview, a third party saying "this is [your] framework." Earned corroboration of your authorship is worth more than any amount of self-assertion.
- **Timestamp and anchor your origination.** Have a clear, datable, canonical home for the idea under your name — a definitive piece that is unmistakably yours and unmistakably first. It won't single-handedly beat a famous name, but it gives the correct version of events a durable anchor that corroboration can point back to.
- **Connect the idea to your broader entity.** An idea credited to a well-defined person with a clear body of related work is stickier than one floating free. The more the concept sits inside a coherent picture of who you are and what you work on, the harder it is for the model to detach it and hand it to someone else.

The honest part

I won't pretend you can always win this. If you share credit-space with someone genuinely famous who has thoroughly colonized a concept, you may never fully reclaim the bare attribution — the gravitational pull of their prominence is real, and no amount of being-right-first fully overcomes it in the short term. That's the same hard truth as sharing a name with a celebrity: sometimes the realistic goal isn't to win the unqualified credit but to become unmistakably associated with the idea *in your context*, so that anyone looking seriously finds you fast.

I'd also caution against the tempting shortcut of loudly, repeatedly asserting "I invented this" everywhere. It reads as self-interested, models discount it, and humans find it off-putting. The durable path is slower and more honest: do the work, keep your name attached to it through a consistent body of output, make your explanation the clearest one available, and earn other people crediting you. Attribution follows a dense, corroborated, well-defined association — and that you can build, even if you can't shortcut it.

If you suspect your ideas are being credited elsewhere, do the uncomfortable thing and check: ask the major AI engines who originated the concepts you built, and see whose name comes back. If it isn't yours, that's not a reason to despair — it's a map of exactly where the association is thin on your side and where to go to work.

Key takeaways

- You can originate an idea and still watch AI credit it to someone more famous who wrote about it later — this is the attribution problem.
- Models attribute by association, not origination: they credit whoever’s name appears most densely and confidently near a concept, which rewards amplification over being first.
- Uncertainty makes it worse — crediting a famous name is the safe, low-risk default, so the obscure originator gets squeezed out.
- For a thought leader this is existential: misattribution compounds, strengthening the wrong association every time the idea is discussed.
- Fix it by attaching your name to the idea repeatedly, owning the clearest definition, earning third-party corroboration of your authorship, and anchoring a canonical origination.
- Honest limit: against a genuinely famous name you may not win the bare credit — aim to be unmistakably associated with the idea in your context instead.

Frequently asked questions

Why does AI credit my idea to someone more famous than me?

Because models attribute by association, not by origination. They don’t check who published first — they report whose name shows up most often and most confidently near the concept. A famous person who amplified your idea gets densely associated with it, while your original, quieter version is thinly associated. The model faithfully reports the association it found, even though that association is wrong about who came first.

Can I fix an attribution that’s already gone to the wrong person?

Sometimes, slowly, and not always completely. The levers are building a consistent body of work that keeps your name attached to the idea, owning the clearest public explanation of it, earning other credible sources to credit you, and anchoring a canonical, datable origination piece. If you’re up against someone genuinely famous who has colonized the concept, you may not win the bare credit — but you can become unmistakably associated with it in your context.

Should I just loudly claim I invented it everywhere?

I’d avoid that. Self-assertion reads as self-interested, models discount it, and people find it off-putting. What actually moves attribution is a dense, corroborated, well-defined association built over time — doing the work, keeping your name on it through consistent output, making your explanation the most useful one, and earning others to credit you. Attribution follows evidence, not volume of self-praise.

About the author. Scott Tischler is the Founder & Chairman of AIrecommend.ai and a practitioner-authority on AI search and Answer Engine Optimization. With 20+ years in marketing technology — including American Express, MetLife, and UBS — and executive and professional study at Wharton, Harvard, and Oxford, he helps businesses become the ones AI recommends.

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scott@airecommend.ai · AIrecommend.ai